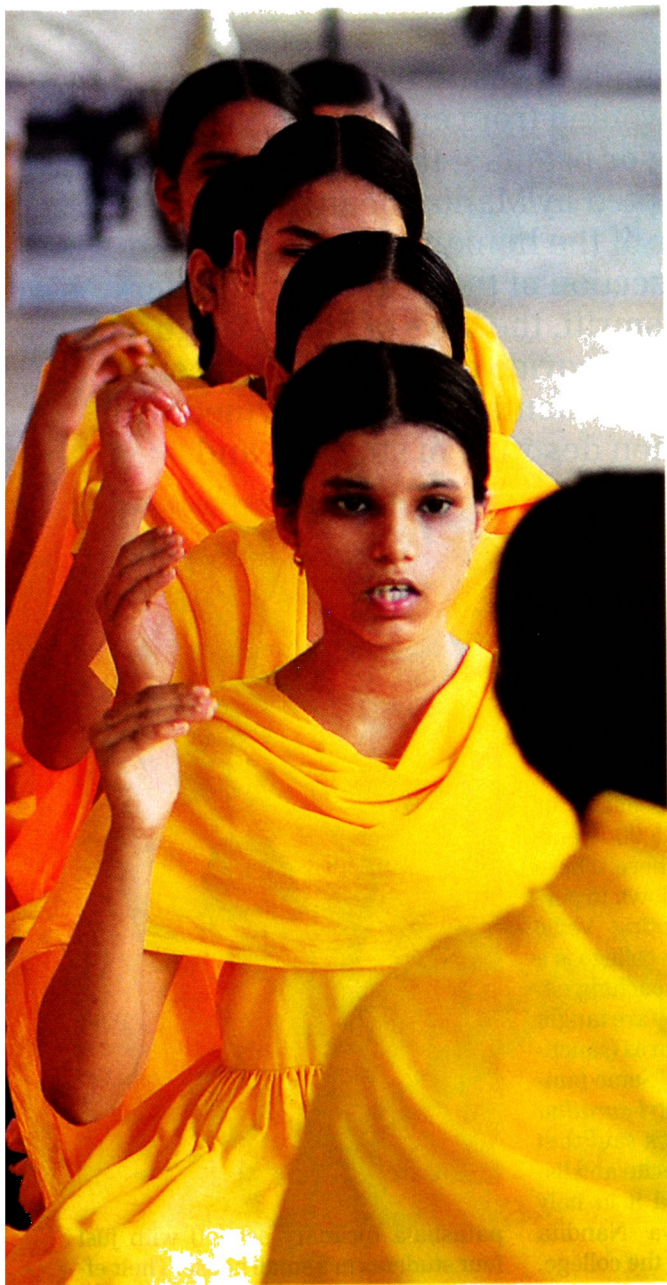




they followed Manusmriti and imposed it on others as they deemed fit. Besides, with the emergence of shankaracharyas, Manusmriti was strengthened and karmakanda was institutionalised in the 9th and 10th centuries," says Tripathi.

Dubbing wrong the claim that Brahmins are by birth, the college principal teaches the students that anyone who can read and understand the Vedas are also entitled to wear the janev (sacred thread). It was established

through scriptures that only thing that makes a man a 'Brahmin' is his aachar (conduct), not caste. Family or ancestors would not be the only basis for being a Brahmin. Hindi writer Dr Anuradha Banerjee, who teaches English literature in a Varanasi college, agrees: "Women used to wear a sacred thread in the Vedic period. In West Bengal there have been mahila purohitis (priests), a movement which was opposed by the Shankaracharya of Puri."

At the college, Sanskrit is the

medium of instruction and the sole spoken language among students and teachers. "We are reviving the ancient system of teaching and training not only to let girls practise religion in its true form but also to turn them into perfect women," says Medha Devi.

The girl students are often called to perform Hindu religious rites ranging from karmakanda, antyeshti (funeral), vivah (wedding), shanti yagna (for peace), grih pravesh (entering a new home) and naamkaran (naming cere-